

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI



Sonia Deals a Slow Hand

DELHI The more things change, the more the Congress remains the same. It is now more than a year since Sonia Gandhi has been planning an organisational reshuffle at the party headquarters to replace Ambika Soni and A.K. Antony after they

shifted to the Council of Ministers. But status quo remains. One reason for the delay is that heir apparent Rahul Gandhi is yet to decide if he wants to be general secretary.

The party's lacklustre performance in Uttar Pradesh has done little to

whet Rahul's appetite for some more organisational responsibility. Even after announcing that he would be reshuffling the Uttar Pradesh state Congress, he's done nothing about it.

The other crucial decision is to do with two chief ministers-turned-general secretaries, Digvijay Singh and Ashok Gehlot. Both Madhya Pradesh and

STALLED: It's status quo for Rahul and Sonia

Rajasthan go to the polls next year, but the party is yet to firm up a chief ministerial candidate for the states. Sonia is said to be keen to promote a fresh face instead of sending the old ones back.

Lobbying has begun, especially in Madhya Pradesh, with PCC chief Subhash Yadav and Jyotiraditya Scindia leading the list of hopefuls. To further complicate matters, there's always Kamal Nath who was quizzed about his chief ministerial aspirations during a recent visit to Chinn-dwara. In Rajasthan, if Gehlot is ruled out, the choice is limited to the state CLP leader B.D. Kalla as Sachin Pilot lacks the requisite experience. More to the point, will Sonia promote any of the GenNext before Rahul makes his move? For now, status quo seems to be the best policy. **by Priya Sahgal**

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The CBI has done it again. After failing to nail Ottavio Quattrocchi in the Bofors payoff case, the agency has used the same line of defence while closing investigations into the theft of Tagore's Nobel medallion. Lack of evidence!

VOICES



"The Congress and Left alliance is a quarrelsome marriage. The Government will not last till 2009 and election can be held any time."

L. K. Advani, BJP leader

"Parliament has to function. When the Rajya Sabha or the Lok Sabha are in session, people watch. Those in Parliament have to be role models for them."

A. P. J. Abdul Kalam, former President

"India can become prosperous only if Bihar becomes prosperous and for this it requires special help."

P. Chidambaram, finance minister

"Once democracy returns to Pakistan, the process of normalcy in relations shall start from where it had been derailed through the stab in the back (of India in) Kargil."

Nawaz Sharif, former Pakistan prime minister

"I enjoy every moment I have on a cricket field, but the recovery times between games these days are difficult, especially for one-day internationals, and that's my major obstacle."

Sachin Tendulkar, cricketer

